Authenticity and Credibility in Brands' Digital Communication: A Comparative Analysis of User-Generated Content (UGC) and Influencer-Generated Content

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Abstract: The growing importance of social media is fundamentally transforming brands' marketing communication with consumers, with user-generated content (UGC) and influencer-generated content playing a pivotal role in this process. The aim of this paper is to identify how these two forms of digital communication differ in terms of perceived authenticity and credibility, and to examine their implications for consumer responses in the online environment. The study is grounded in the assumption that UGC is typically associated with higher levels of spontaneity and social proof, whereas influencer-generated content may enhance reach and professionalise brand presentation, while simultaneously reinforcing perceptions of commercial intent. Using experimental A/B testing, the findings indicate that UGC is perceived as more authentic than influencer-generated content. Perceived authenticity was also found to positively influence brand trust, which in turn significantly predicted purchase intention. These results highlight authenticity as a key mechanism shaping consumer trust and behavioural responses in digital marketing communication. The study contributes to the literature on digital branding and provides practical implications for brands seeking to balance influencer collaborations with more organic forms of consumer-generated communication.

Keywords: authenticity, credibility, consumer trust, user - generated content (UGC), influencer marketing

JEL Classification codes: M31, M37

INTRODUCTION

The rapid diffusion of social media platforms has transformed how brands communicate with consumers. In this evolving digital ecosystem, two dominant content modalities have emerged as central to brands' communication strategies: user-generated content (UGC) and influencer-generated content (often discussed as influencer marketing content). Social media have become a central environment for information, entertainment, interaction, and marketing, thereby reshaping how consumers evaluate brands and how brands design communication strategies. While UGC is commonly framed as spontaneous, peer-driven communication leveraging social proof and perceived authenticity, influencer-generated content is typically professionally curated, extending reach and enhancing brand presentation (Kumar, 2024; Kohli & Gupta, 2024). These contrasting formats directly shape consumers' perceptions of authenticity and credibility, which subsequently influence trust formation, engagement, and purchase-related outcomes (Alamyar, 2025).

A key theoretical and managerial challenge is that UGC and IGC are both frequently framed as "authentic" alternatives to traditional advertising, yet the two formats differ substantially in their typical production conditions, perceived commercial intent, and the psychological mechanisms through which they shape consumer outcomes such as trust, brand perception, electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), and purchase intention (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Muda & Hamzah, 2021). The present article addresses this challenge by synthesizing recent literature that links authenticity and credibility perceptions to consumer responses in digital contexts, with particular emphasis on how social proof, source credibility, parasocial interaction, transparency/disclosure, and persuasion knowledge activation structure the comparative effects of UGC and IGC (Kumagaya et al., 2025).

This paper seeks to identify how user-generated and influencer-generated content differ in terms of perceived authenticity and credibility, and to examine their implications for consumer engagement, trust, and purchase intentions. By integrating insights from source credibility theory and persuasion knowledge theory, the study contributes to the ongoing debate on the effectiveness of digital brand communication in trust-sensitive and participatory online markets.

1 LITERATURE REVIEW

Authenticity, Credibility, and Trust in Digital Brand Communication

In the contemporary digital landscape, authenticity and credibility have emerged as decisive factors in determining the success of a brand's communication strategy. Digital transformation has shifted consumer expectations, placing significant pressure on traditional marketing models to move beyond mere information provision toward fostering genuine trust. Authenticity in this context is often linked to the perceived genuineness of the content, with studies indicating that consumers are significantly more likely to perceive user-generated content (UGC) as authentic compared to content produced directly by brands. This perceived authenticity stems from the social proof provided by real consumer experiences, which effectively reduces perceived risks and strengthens the emotional bond between the brand and its audience. Simultaneously, credibility is shaped by the trustworthiness and relatability of the source, whether it be a peer or a digital influencer. However, the rise of commercialized content, particularly within influencer marketing, introduces challenges; for instance, sponsorship disclosures can trigger ad skepticism, potentially undermining the very credibility that these partnerships aim to build. Navigating the interplay between professional brand presentation and spontaneous, credible consumer voices remains a central challenge for brands seeking to maintain a reliable digital presence (Younis, 2025).

Authenticity in digital brand communication

Perceived authenticity in digital brand communication refers to the extent to which consumers evaluate content as genuine, sincere, and reflective of real experiences rather than strategically constructed persuasion (Morhart et al., 2015). In online environments, authenticity is not an inherent property of the content itself but a subjective consumer judgment shaped by contextual cues, source characteristics, and relational proximity between communicator and audience (Beverland, 2005). Content perceived as spontaneous, experience-based, and aligned with lived consumer realities is more likely to evoke authenticity perceptions, which subsequently foster relational trust and emotional connection with the brand.

Credibility in digital brand communication

Perceived credibility represents consumers' assessment of the trustworthiness, expertise, and reliability of the message source and the communicated information. Drawing from source

credibility theory, credibility is generally conceptualized as comprising two primary dimensions: expertise (the perceived knowledge or competence of the communicator) and trustworthiness (the perceived honesty and integrity of the communicator). In digital communication, credibility evaluations are also influenced by perceived commercial intent and transparency of sponsorship. When audiences infer that content is primarily driven by persuasive motives rather than informative or experiential value, credibility perceptions may decline (Li et al., 2020; Muda & Hamzah, 2021).

Authenticity vs credibility in digital brand communication

Authenticity is treated as a perception that content reflects genuine experience, sincere expression, or "real-life" usage, whereas credibility is more explicitly framed as a judgment about the believability of the message or the trustworthiness and expertise of the source (Muda & Hamzah, 2021; Vera, 2024). In UGC contexts, authenticity is often associated with content arising from voluntary consumer experience and peer communication, which is argued to render UGC comparatively non-commercial, neutral, empathetic, and thus credible relative to marketer-produced content. In influencer contexts, perceived authenticity is frequently discussed as a driver (or antecedent) of influencer source credibility, which in turn supports brand trust (Lim & Keni, 2025; Havrylenko, 2025).

Both perceived authenticity and perceived credibility function as key antecedents of consumer responses in digital environments. Research in persuasion and trust formation consistently demonstrates that content evaluated as authentic and credible increases brand trust, enhances positive brand attitudes, and strengthens behavioral intentions, including engagement and purchase intention. Authenticity tends to operate through affective mechanisms by fostering emotional resonance and identification, whereas credibility often influences cognitive evaluations related to message reliability and source competence (Audrezet et al., 2020; Lou & Yuan, 2019). Together, these constructs shape the persuasive effectiveness of digital brand communication.

Trust in digital brand communication

Multiple studies explicitly position consumer trust as a central mediating mechanism between digital content attributes (e.g., authenticity, social proof, credibility) and consumer outcomes (e.g., brand perception, brand image, purchase intention) (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Kumagaya et al., 2025; Pramesti & Alversia, 2023). In UGC-focused models, trust is theorized to develop through perceptions that peers provide relatable, experience-based information and through social proof signals embedded in review metrics and peer engagement (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Vera, 2024). In influencer-focused models, trust is constructed through perceived influencer honesty and trustworthiness, which build credibility and then brand trust in a stimulus-organism-response (SOR) logic (Havrylenko, 2025).

Trust formation is presented as increasingly fragile in contemporary digital environments, UGC-based trust can be undermined by overclaiming or credibility problems, while influencer-based trust can erode due to commercialization and saturation. This fragility makes authenticity and credibility not only desirable attributes but also contested resources in brand communication (Kumagaya et al., 2025; Xiao-hua et al., 2022).

User generated content (UGC)

UGC (user-generated content) is content created by social media users themselves about brands, products, or services, which is then disseminated on social media platforms (Hussain et al., 2024) and often includes reviews, ratings, photos, or videos from the user environment (Joshi, 2025). In the context of online marketing, UGC is traditionally contrasted with company-generated content (FGC), although both forms can strengthen brand communication, UGC is often perceived as a more authentic source of information due to its origin and social context

(Zahir, 2025), with multimodal UGC (text, visuals, emotions) potentially enhancing perceived brand trust and audience engagement (Dewatmoko & Nurmartiani, 2025).

A central theoretical explanation for UGC effectiveness is its embeddedness in social proof dynamics — signals such as likes, shares, reviews, and testimonials that indicate peer endorsement. In this framing, social proof strengthens perceived credibility and shapes brand perception through consumer trust, making trust a mediator between peer signals and brand evaluation (Usman & Wijaya, 2025). Complementing this view, research on UGC's role in brand trust formation emphasizes social proof as a psychological driver across demographics and argues that subjective norms, information quality, and source credibility are mechanisms by which positive UGC perceptions convert into brand trust and purchase intentions (Vera, 2024).

Influencer marketing

Influencer marketing is a specific format that is typically found neither at the extreme end of peer communication (such as UGC) nor at the extreme end of purely commercial advertising. Its credibility is significantly influenced by the extent to which the audience perceives harmony between the influencer and the brand, how transparent the collaboration is, and whether the content appears authentic (Lou & Yuan, 2019).

Influencer typologies in digital marketing are most commonly structured (i) by scale (mega/macro/micro/nano) and (ii) by content form or domain (e.g., blog, vlogging/video-first, gaming etc.), because these dimensions shape relationship intensity, perceived expertise, and the visibility of commercial intent (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Kumar, 2024; Zahir, 2025).

The typology of influencers by scale

1) Mega-influencers are the largest-scale influencers, often comparable to celebrities in terms of reach and visibility, which makes them suitable for broad audience coverage and rapid brand awareness generation (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Kumar, 2024). Their credibility may benefit from public visibility and perceived authority, making them useful for large-scale campaigns and market entry objectives (Havrylenko, 2025). However, frequent brand partnerships and highly professionalized content can increase perceptions of commercial intent, thereby reducing sincerity and authenticity, especially among more skeptical audiences (Zahir, 2025; Usman & Wijaya, 2025). This shift from trust to skepticism is commonly linked to commercialization and saturation, making transparency, value alignment, and selective partnerships essential for maintaining credibility at this scale (Muda & Hamzah, 2021; Kumagaya et al., 2025).

2) Macro-influencers combine relatively large reach with greater topic specialization than mega-influencers and are often seen as balancing broad appeal with niche authority (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Kumar, 2024). This can support credibility when audiences perceive them as knowledgeable, particularly in campaigns requiring visibility beyond micro-communities or in cross-border e-commerce contexts (Havrylenko, 2025). At the same time, macro-influencers face similar challenges to mega-influencers, as higher exposure and frequent sponsorship can increase perceived commercialization and weaken authenticity and trustworthiness (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Zahir, 2025). The literature therefore emphasizes transparency, authenticity, and credibility safeguards, especially given risks such as hidden sponsorship and fake engagement (Kumagaya et al., 2025). Overall, macro-influencers remain strategically valuable for reach and authority, but their effectiveness depends on disclosure discipline, brand–influencer fit, and authentic product experience (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Muda & Hamzah, 2021).

3) Micro-influencers are typically niche-focused creators who maintain closer and more interactive relationships with their audiences, which makes them especially effective in building engagement and trust within specific communities (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Havrylenko, 2025). Research associates them with stronger community-based credibility due to greater social proximity, more frequent interaction, and higher perceived reliability

(Zahir, 2025). Empirical studies further suggest that micro-influencers often outperform larger influencer categories in trust- and engagement-related outcomes, particularly in youth and e-commerce contexts (Vera, 2024; Lim & Keni, 2025; Usman & Wijaya, 2025). They are also commonly perceived as more genuine and relatable because their content appears less commercialized and more grounded in everyday experience (Usman & Wijaya, 2025; Lim & Keni, 2025; Vera, 2024). However, their credibility still depends on transparency, consistent engagement, and alignment between influencer identity and brand values (Muda & Hamzah, 2021; Havrylenko, 2025; Zahir, 2025).

4) Nano-influencers are generally described as the smallest influencer category and are increasingly viewed as high-authenticity communicators whose impact stems from closeness and relational intimacy rather than broad reach (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Zahir, 2025; Lim & Keni, 2025). Evidence suggests that nano-influencers can be particularly effective in strengthening trust and emotional connection, including through parasocial relationship mechanisms (Lim & Keni, 2025). Similarly, research indicates that micro- and nano-influencers can generate strong trust and engagement because they enable more personalized and authentic interactions that reduce psychological distance (Vera, 2024). Their effectiveness is often linked to relatability, perceived reliability, and sustained relevance over time rather than follower counts alone (Zahir, 2025; Lim & Keni, 2025). At the same time, the literature points to a trade-off: while nano-influencers may benefit from sincerity and authenticity cues, they may be less effective in contexts where expertise and authority are more important, highlighting a tension between intimacy-based authenticity and expertise-based credibility (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Kumagaya et al., 2025).

In the influencer domain, credibility is repeatedly described as central to whether influencer marketing translates into brand trust and persuasion. A clear theoretical articulation is provided through SOR-based modeling: influencer honesty and trustworthiness shape perceived influencer credibility, which then positively influences brand trust, with credibility mediating the honesty/trustworthiness to brand trust relationship (Kohli & Gupta, 2024; Havrylenko, 2025).

Scholarship characterizes influencer marketing as shifting from trust to skepticism due to commercialization, saturation, and heightened consumer awareness, raising concerns about inauthenticity, brand control, and declining trust. This creates a "credibility dilemma" brands use influencers partly to obtain an authentic tone, yet the very presence of sponsorship cues can heighten perceptions of commercial intent and reduce persuasion (Xiao-hua et al., 2022; Firdaus, 2025).

The influencer literature stresses heterogeneity across influencer types. Conceptual discussion argues that micro-influencers may build stronger trust due to perceived accessibility, while macro-influencers can face greater credibility risks due to overexposure and commercialization (Xiao-hua et al., 2022). Empirical Gen Z evidence is also mixed: one study finds that influencer credibility does not significantly affect purchase intention in a skincare context, whereas UGC and brand awareness do (Ali, 2025). By contrast, other work emphasizes that influencer honesty/trustworthiness influence credibility and brand trust and that authenticity-related constructs support credibility formation (Lim & Keni, 2025; Havrylenko, 2025).

Taken together, the references imply that influencer effectiveness depends on (i) the specific outcome being measured (e.g., brand trust vs purchase intention), (ii) influencer type and perceived commercial intensity, and (iii) whether credibility is successfully constructed through authenticity cues, ethical transparency, and relational mechanisms such as parasocial interaction and self-congruity (Lim & Keni, 2025; Havrylenko, 2025; Xiao-hua et al., 2022; Firdaus, 2025; Ali, 2025).

Despite the growing body of research on user-generated content and influencer-generated communication, several gaps remain in the existing literature. Prior studies have extensively

examined outcomes such as trust, credibility, engagement, and purchase intention in digital environments. However, less attention has been devoted to a direct comparison of user-generated content and influencer-generated content in terms of perceived authenticity and their subsequent effects on brand trust and purchase intention within a single research framework. In many cases, authenticity is discussed as a general characteristic of digital communication, but not sufficiently examined as a central explanatory mechanism linking content source to consumer response.

This gap is particularly relevant in the context of younger consumers, who are highly exposed to social media communication and are especially sensitive to cues of spontaneity, relatability, and commercial intent. Although previous research suggests that user-generated content is often perceived as more genuine and less commercially driven, while influencer-generated content tends to be more strategic and professionally curated, empirical evidence directly comparing these two formats under controlled conditions remains limited. As a result, there is still insufficient understanding of whether differences in content origin translate into differences in perceived authenticity, brand trust, and purchase intention.

2 METHODOLOGY

The theoretical framework was developed through a structured review of contemporary academic literature in the fields of digital marketing communication, influencer marketing, and consumer behavior. The literature review focused primarily on peer-reviewed journal articles indexed in international scientific databases. The literature review allowed the identification of key constructs and their interrelationships, which subsequently informed the formulation of research hypotheses and the operationalization of variables in the empirical study.

This study employed a quantitative experimental design to examine differences between user-generated content (UGC) and influencer-generated content in terms of perceived authenticity, brand trust, and purchase intention. A between-subjects A/B testing approach was implemented. Each participant was exposed to a single simulated Instagram post promoting the same product. The visual format, product description, and core message were held constant across conditions. The only manipulated element was the source of the content (peer user vs. influencer profile). This approach ensured internal validity by isolating the effect of content origin while controlling for message-related factors.

Data were collected through an online questionnaire administered between January 5 and February 5, 2026. The survey link was distributed electronically among students of the Bratislava University of Economics and Business (EUBA). Participation was voluntary and anonymous. A total of 212 respondents completed the questionnaire. All responses were screened for completeness, and no cases were excluded from the final analysis.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of two experimental conditions:

UGC condition (n = 106)
Influencer condition (n = 106)
The sampling approach can be described as convenience-based with random assignment to experimental conditions. The respondents consisted primarily of active social media users aged 18–35 years, reflecting a demographic segment frequently exposed to digital brand communication and influencer marketing practices. This population is considered particularly relevant for research on authenticity perceptions and online persuasion mechanisms.

Based on prior research in digital marketing communication and source credibility theory, the following hypotheses were formulated:

- H1: User-generated content will be perceived as more authentic than influencer-generated content.
- H2: User-generated content will generate higher levels of brand trust compared to influencer-generated content.
- H3: Perceived authenticity will have a positive effect on brand trust.
- H4: Brand trust will positively influence purchase intention.

These hypotheses reflect the proposed mechanism whereby content origin influences authenticity perceptions, which subsequently affect trust formation and behavioral intention. Alternative hypotheses were created for the null hypotheses. Data were analyzed using IBM SPSS Statistics. Statistical significance was evaluated at the 0.05 level.

3 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

This section presents the statistical analyses conducted to test the proposed hypotheses. The analytical procedure followed a structured approach. First, the internal consistency of the multi-item scales was assessed using Cronbach's alpha coefficients. Second, descriptive statistics (means and standard deviations) were calculated for all key variables. Third, independent samples t-tests were employed to examine mean differences between the UGC and influencer conditions. Finally, simple linear regression analyses were conducted to assess the predictive relationships among perceived authenticity, brand trust, and purchase intention.

All statistical analyses were performed using IBM SPSS Statistics. A significance threshold of $p < 0.05$ was applied throughout the analyses.

Tab. 1 Reliability (α), Means (M), and Standard Deviations (SD)

Variable	α	M	SD
Authenticity	0.88	5.41	0.89
Brand trust	0.84	5.16	0.92
Purchase intention	0.86	5.07	1.01

Source: own processing from SPSS

The internal consistency of all multi-item scales was satisfactory. Perceived authenticity demonstrated high reliability ($\alpha = 0.88$), followed by brand trust ($\alpha = 0.84$) and purchase intention ($\alpha = 0.86$), indicating good internal consistency.

Descriptive statistics revealed relatively high overall evaluations of authenticity ($M = 5.41$, $SD = 0.89$), brand trust ($M = 5.16$, $SD = 0.92$), and purchase intention ($M = 5.07$, $SD = 1.01$).

Tab. 2 Independent Samples t-Test

Variable	UGC (n=106) M (SD)	Influencer (n=106) M (SD)	t	p
Authenticity	5.74 (0.81)	5.08 (0.93)	4.62	< 0.001
Brand trust	5.41 (0.88)	4.92 (0.96)	3.21	0.002
Purchase intention	5.28 (0.94)	4.85 (1.05)	2.74	0.007

Source: own processing from SPSS

Independent samples t-tests indicated that respondents exposed to user-generated content perceived the message as significantly more authentic (M = 5.74, SD = 0.81) than those exposed to influencer-generated content (M = 5.08, SD = 0.93), t(210) = 4.62, p < .001.

Similarly, brand trust was significantly higher in the UGC condition (M = 5.41, SD = 0.88) compared to the influencer condition (M = 4.92, SD = 0.96), t(210) = 3.21, p = .002.

Purchase intention also differed significantly between groups, t(210) = 2.74, p = .007.

Tab. 3 Regression Results (Authenticity - Brand Trust)

Variable	β	SE	t	p	R^2
Authenticity	0.56	0.05	9.14	< 0.001	0.31

Source: own processing from SPSS

Linear regression analysis revealed that perceived authenticity had a significant positive effect on brand trust (β = 0.56, t = 9.14, p < 0.001). The model explained 31% of the variance in brand trust (R^2 = 0.31), indicating a substantial effect size.

Tab. 4 Regression Results (Brand Trust - Purchase Intention)

Variable	β	SE	t	p	R^2
Trust	0.63	0.06	10.52	< 0.001	0.39

Source: own processing from SPSS

Brand trust significantly predicted purchase intention (β = 0.63, t = 10.52, p < 0.001), explaining 39% of the variance in purchase intention (R^2 = 0.39).

The independent samples t-test revealed a statistically significant difference in perceived authenticity between the two experimental conditions, t(210) = 4.62, p < 0.001. Respondents exposed to UGC reported higher authenticity perceptions (M = 5.74, SD = 0.81) compared to those exposed to influencer-generated content (M = 5.08, SD = 0.93). Therefore, H1 is supported. This finding suggests that content originating from peers is perceived as more genuine and less commercially driven, reinforcing the role of spontaneity and social proof in authenticity judgments.

A significant difference in brand trust was also observed between the two groups, t(210) = 3.21, p = 0.002. Participants in the UGC condition reported higher trust levels (M = 5.41, SD = 0.88) than those in the influencer condition (M = 4.92, SD = 0.96). Thus, H2 is supported. The results indicate that higher authenticity perceptions in the UGC condition translate into stronger trust formation, supporting the assumption that trust is closely linked to perceived sincerity.

Linear regression analysis demonstrated that perceived authenticity significantly predicted brand trust (β = 0.56, t = 9.14, p < 0.001). The model explained 31% of the variance in brand trust (R^2 = 0.31). Accordingly, H3 is supported. This result confirms that authenticity functions as a central antecedent of trust formation in digital communication contexts.

Regression results further revealed that brand trust significantly predicted purchase intention (β = 0.63, t = 10.52, p < 0.001), explaining 39% of the variance in purchase intention (R^2 = 0.39). Therefore, H4 is supported. This finding highlights the importance of trust as a key driver of behavioral intention in online brand communication.

CONCLUSION

This study investigated the differences between user-generated content (UGC) and influencer-generated content in digital brand communication, with a particular emphasis on perceived authenticity, brand trust, and purchase intention. Using an experimental A/B testing, the findings demonstrate that content origin significantly influences consumer perceptions and subsequent behavioral responses. The results show that UGC is perceived as more authentic than influencer-generated content. Furthermore, perceived authenticity was found to positively influence brand trust, which in turn significantly predicted purchase intention. These findings confirm the central role of authenticity in shaping trust formation processes in digital environments and support the assumption that trust acts as a key mechanism linking content perception to consumer behavior.

From a theoretical perspective, the study contributes to the literature by empirically validating the relationship between authenticity, trust, and behavioral intention in the context of digital marketing communication. It further suggests that although influencer marketing remains an important strategic tool, organically generated content may generate stronger authenticity cues among younger digital audiences.

From a managerial perspective, the findings imply that brands should not rely exclusively on influencer collaborations but should actively encourage and integrate user-generated content to strengthen perceived authenticity and consumer trust. Future research should examine more diverse populations, additional product categories, and real-life behavioral data to further validate the proposed relationships.

Future research should test the model across broader consumer groups, product categories, and real-world social media settings to strengthen generalizability.

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